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Highland plateau Amhara of Ethiopia

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5.1.1.3 Regional variation • 5.1.1.4 Literature; special argots

The use of the call "Gurag[unknown]e" for laborer has been expressly forbidden, because it is now considered insulting to that hardworking ethnic group, and the call "coolie" has been purposely imported. Furthermore, increased use is made in Addis Ababa Amharic of Giiz abstracts for modern purposes, such as the suffix - [unknown]nn[unknown]t, which can be attached to most Amharic content words to render an abstraction. Modernization, which has recently introduced such new cultural phenomena into Addis Ababa as the adult, unmarried "Miss" produced a new term to describe the new phenomenon: the old w[unknown]yz[unknown]ro (married, noble lady, Mrs.) is amended to the new concept w[unknown]yz[unknown]rit (adult though unmarried Miss), by use of a diminutive suffix -it. This term is still unknown in the rural Amhara provinces, but is entering through the provincial capitals, such as Gonder, at the present time.

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5.1.1.4 Literature; special argots

The religious character of most of the traditional Amharic-Giiz literature has already been described in connection with the church.

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Some of the material of liturgy finds its way into lay usage. Rhymes, g[unknown]t'[unknown]m, originally composed for devotional poetry, have long found their way in to chants of praise sung to warlords, feudal nobles, the king, and by extension, philosophic-sentimental poetry in general.

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Oral folk literature contains numerous stories resembling Aesop's fables, in which witty repartee among or with animals is featured (Courlander and Leslau 1950).

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Individual poets and other authors, if they existed in number, have largely been forgotten, because of the cultural prohibition against writing down any but sacred matter, and the restricted literacy. But a fortunate exception exists in the person of a Gonderine wit named al[unknown]k'a g[unknown]br[unknown]-hanna, who was a contemporary of Emperor Minilik II in the late nineteenth century (Messing 1957:69-72). He apparently did not write down any of his many witticisms, but since he lived fairly recently, commuting between his home in Gonder and the then incipient city of Addis Ababa, he is still popularly as well as officially identified with his stories in both localities, and some of the anecdotes even tie his person to historical events.

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He was a master of sewassiw and of the pun which utilizes phonological and grammatical possibilities to make an ironic observation and befuddle the unwary, so that they become public laughing stocks. Sometimes the joke was on his own Rabelaisian appetites in food and sex. More often he spoofed the pomposities of feudal and even royal powers, their love for amassing rules and regulations for their courts, and the pretended puritan piety of the priests, behind which facade he recognized witty insight into the minds of men, whose salty comments and behavior in private life he liked to burlesque. For example:

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"One day the servant of a witty priest suffered from a chigger (sandflea) embedded in his foot. The priest pried  240 it out with a pin and threw it into the fire. A friend, watching this, objected jokingly, saying: "Why did you do this? May it not multiply in the fire?" Replied the priest: "it may be warmed, but not 'done up' (y[unknown]ss[unknown]rral) also means begotten through sexual intercourse).

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Literary Texts

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